

Natchez Trace Parkway

Lower Trace Self-Guided Cycling Tour
Natchez, MS → Rocky Springs, MS
Your route. Your pace. Your adventure.

TOTAL DISTANCE	DURATION	DIFFICULTY	BIKE TYPE	BEST SEASON
~82 Miles	See itinerary	Beginner	E-Bike	Spring / Fall

ESSENTIAL INFORMATION

START POINT	Natchez Visitor Center, Natchez, MS (Milepost 0)
END POINT	Rocky Springs Campsite, MS (Milepost 54.8)
RESUPPLY	Natchez (start), Port Gibson (MP 39.2) — stock up, limited options between
CASH	Bring cash — many small towns and local restaurants are cash only
CELL SERVICE	Spotty in many sections — download offline maps before departing
TRAFFIC	No trucks or commercial vehicles ever permitted on the Parkway
WATER	Available at NPS visitor centers and campgrounds — carry 2L minimum
EMERGENCY	NPS Ranger Station: (601) 446-6672 · Call 911 for emergencies
LODGING	B&Bs; and small inns — see recommendations per day below

SEASONAL NOTES — FALL

September–November brings cooler temps and fall color. October is the sweet spot. Fewer crowds than spring. B&Bs; more available but still book ahead for weekends. Daylight shorter — plan to finish riding by 5:30pm in November.

GETTING THERE & LOGISTICS

YOUR TRIP	Fly into Jackson–Evers International Airport (JAN), ~90 min from Natchez. Downtown Karla Brown offers bike-friendly shuttle service from Jackson airport to Natchez — approximately \$45/person including your bike. Book in advance: find her via NatchezTraceTravel.com
BIKE SHIPPING	BikeFlights.com ships your bike to your hotel and back home. Starts around \$60 each way. Book 1–2 weeks ahead.

DAY 1 — ARRIVAL & NATCHEZ EXPLORATION

Arrive in Natchez — one of the oldest cities on the Mississippi River and the southern terminus of the Trace. Spend the afternoon exploring the historic downtown, the Mississippi bluffs, and the antebellum mansions that made this one of pre-Civil War America's wealthiest cities. Dine along the bluffs tonight — the Mississippi catfish here is exceptional.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
—	Natchez Bluffs	Walk	Stunning overlooks of the Mississippi River. Best at sunset.
—	Antebellum Mansions	Tour	Stanton Hall, Longwood, Dunleith — tours available. Book ahead in spring.
—	Downtown Natchez	Explore	Historic Main Street, local restaurants, shops. Cash for local spots.
—	Overnight: Natchez	—	See lodging recommendations below.

DAY 2 — NATCHEZ TO EMERALD MOUND (~28 miles · ~1,200 ft)

Your first day of riding. The Parkway wraps you in forest and calm immediately. Easy pace — stop at every historical marker. The day ends just past Mount Locust, the oldest inn on the Old Trace.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
0.0	Natchez Visitor Center — START	Head N	Parking, restrooms, water. Official Parkway start.
1.2	Under-the-Hill area	Continue N	Optional last coffee/food stop before the Trace.
10.3	Emerald Mound	Turn R	MUST STOP. 2nd largest Native American mound in US. Allow 30 min.
15.5	Mount Locust Historic Inn	Continue N	Oldest remaining inn on the Old Natchez Trace. NPS interpretive site.
17.5	Loess Bluff	Continue N	Unique geological formation. Short walk to overlook.
25.0	Sunken Trace	Continue N	Walk the original sunken trail worn by centuries of foot traffic.
28.0	Rocky Branch — END DAY 2	Exit	Short ride to Port Gibson area lodging. Quiet roads.

DAY 3 — PORT GIBSON AREA TO WINDSOR RUINS (~24 miles · ~1,100 ft)

The most memorable day on the Lower Trace — entirely at your own pace. The Windsor Ruins detour is the highlight of the entire route. Take your time. Afternoon is free to explore Port Gibson on foot.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
0.0	Re-enter Natchez Trace Pkwy	Head N	Resume from MP 30. Continue northbound.
11.0	Grindstone Ford / Mangum Mound	Continue N	Ancient mound and creek crossing. Good shaded rest stop.
12.0	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	Good lunch stop. Restrooms and water available.
13.2	PORT GIBSON — END DAY 3	Exit L	Turn left toward town. RESUPPLY HERE.

DAY 4 — PORT GIBSON TO ROCKY SPRINGS (~26 miles · ~1,300 ft)

A leisurely final riding day with the best detour on the route — Windsor Ruins. The day ends at Rocky Springs, a ghost town slowly reclaimed by forest.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
39.2	Port Gibson — START DAY 4	To Pkwy	Stock up food and water. Limited resupply ahead.
41.0	Windsor Ruins Turnoff	Turn LEFT	MUST STOP. 23 haunting columns in the forest. Allow 45-60 min.
41.5	Return to Parkway	Turn RIGHT	Rejoin Parkway heading north.
45.7	Sunken Trace (2nd section)	Continue N	Short walk, very worth it.
47.5	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	LAST WATER before Rocky Springs. Fill all bottles.
50.0	Owens Creek Waterfall	Continue N	Small but lovely waterfall. Easy 2-min walk off road.
54.8	Rocky Springs — END	Turn R	Free NPS camping. Water on site. Ghost town ruins and 1837 church.

RECOMMENDED GEAR

CATEGORY	ESSENTIALS	NICE TO HAVE
Bike	Road or hybrid bike, spare tubes x2, pump, multi-tool, chain lube	Handlebar bag or small frame bag
Luggage	Small backpack or handlebar bag — B&Bs; carry your overnight essentials	Lightweight dry bag for rain protection
Food & Water	2x bottles minimum, snacks for the day — meals at restaurants nightly	Electrolyte tabs for hot days
Navigation	Offline maps downloaded (Google Maps or Gaia GPS), this cue sheet	Garmin or Wahoo GPS with GPX loaded
Clothing	Padded shorts, jersey x2, lightweight rain jacket, arm warmers	Chamois cream, sun sleeves for hot days
Safety	Front and rear lights, helmet, ID, emergency contacts, basic first aid	Personal locator beacon for remote sections
Other	Cash \$50+ minimum, sunscreen, insect repellent (essential spring)	Small padlock for bike at overnight stops

NAVIGATION & DIGITAL MAPS

RESOURCE	HOW TO USE	WHERE TO GET IT
GPX File	Import to Garmin, Wahoo, Komoot, Ride with GPS, or Apple Maps	Included in your download from openride.bike
Ride with GPS	View interactive map, turn cues on your phone, export GPX	ridewithgps.com — search OpenRide Natchez Trace
Google Maps Offline	Download the region over WiFi before your trip	Open Google Maps → find area → tap Download
NPS Parkway Map	Official map with all mileposts, facilities, campgrounds marked	nps.gov/natr — free PDF download
Komoot	Excellent cycling-specific routing and navigation app	komoot.com — search Natchez Trace

This route guide was curated by a professional bicycle tour guide with over 10 years of experience leading tours on the Natchez Trace Parkway. Every stop, every note, and every recommendation comes from real miles ridden on this road.

Questions or feedback? Visit openride.bike — and share your ride photos with #OpenRide.